COUNTRY REPORTS: MALI

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Status report

GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA · GEOPOLITICS

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

The government has acknowledged that implementation of the Mali Numérique 2020 strategy was not successful, and a replacement National Digital Economy Strategy for 2024-2028 remains under development (2025). Until that lands, the instrument covering the estate is the 2015 national strategy for the development of the digital economy, which reaches across broadband and universal access, cybersecurity, data centres and cloud services, data protection, digital identification, digital payments, digital signatures, e-commerce and e-waste — the whole field in a document now a decade old.

Sectoral policy has moved where the umbrella has not. The Council of Ministers approved a national cybersecurity strategy for 2026-2030 in December 2025, and a national financial inclusion strategy adopted in June 2022 targets rural populations, women, youth and smaller enterprises.

The wider governance record it sits in is falling. Mali scored 43.2 out of 100 for overall governance in the 2024 Ibrahim Index, 37th of 54 African states and below the African average of 49.3, having lost 4.6 points over 2014-2023 against an African average that rose 1.0 point (2023). Across the index's 96 indicators Mali improved on 43 and declined on 51, and scored below the African average on 59 of them (2023). Its best showing is on the administrative and economic foundations: Foundations for Economic Opportunity, covering public administration, infrastructure, the business environment and the rural economy, is, with Human Development, the country's most improved category, at 48.1 out of 100, 29th of 54 and up 1.9 points over the decade (2023).

Legislation and regulation

The newest instrument on Mali's digital statute book is a decree of 25 February 2026 approving the national cybersecurity strategy and its 2026-2030 action plan, gazetted on 6 March 2026 without the annexed strategy text. The statutes beneath it are older than the systems running on them: Ordonnance n° 2011-023/P-RM of 28 September 2011 governs telecommunications, information and communication technologies and posts, carrying the universal access arrangements, Loi n° 2016-012 of 6 May 2016 covers electronic transactions, exchanges and services, Loi n° 2019-056 carries the repression of cybercrime, and Loi n° 2016-005 of 24 February 2016 governs public statistics.

Mali's telecoms regulator circulated a message on 12 March 2026 reiterating the prohibition on importing, selling or using non-homologated Starlink and WiFi Zone equipment, and warning of sanctions. The restriction runs off the existing equipment-homologation regime: the reiteration enacts no new statute and cites no article numbers.

Platform-content enforcement rests on the same statute book. A justice ministry communiqué of 29 July 2026 enumerates penal qualifications already in force, creates no new offence and notifies no platform, and it treats the staging, filming, publication and commentary of images of child depravity as offences falling "notamment de la cybercriminalité" — a content-liability reading of the cybercrime law arrived at by ministerial instruction rather than by amendment.

The instruments themselves are older. Mali enacted a cybercrime law in 2019, published in the Journal Officiel. Law No. 2013-015 of 21 May 2013 restricts cross-border transfers of personal data to countries judged to offer adequate protection and imposes no general requirement that data be stored inside the country, and a law of 13 December 2024 criminalises data breaches, with the constitution of 23 July 2023 giving personal-data protection constitutional recognition.

There is no consolidated digital identity act: the NINA number and the biometric card rest on Law No. 06-040 of 11 August 2006 on the national identification number, Law No. 06-024 of 2006 on civil status and Decree No. 2022-0639/PT-RM, with no digital-ID-specific regulation in force (2025).

Each of Mali's 2026 moves on the digital estate — an equipment reminder to importers and users, an instruction to prosecutors, a conviction in the cybercrime court — applies law already in force, and none of them creates a new statute.

Data protection

Mali's data protection authority fined a Bamako clinic 5 million FCFA for obstructing one of its verification missions (2025), one end of a caseload that also runs to more than 100 formal notices issued to data controllers and some 2,000 declaratory files examined from organisations registering their personal-data processing (October 2025). In December 2025 the APDP opened a regional antenna in Ségou, and by September 2026 it had regional offices at Kayes, Sikasso, Ségou and Mopti. On 23 September 2026 it signed a cooperation agreement with Togo's authority on information exchange, complaints handling, compliance checks and staff training.

The largest processing of personal data on the record sits outside that caseload: an AI provider's misuse report of September 2026 describes Lakana 360, a platform built for the state security agency that monitors about 25 million SIM cards across all three mobile operators and captures call records, messages and voice traffic, with a warrant requirement removed from one component. No response from the authority and no legal basis for the interception is on record.

The authority has been operational since 2016 as an independent body of 15 members serving seven-year terms, funded from the state budget and empowered to investigate complaints, demand evidence and impose sanctions, established under Law No. 2013-015 of 21 May 2013.

What the framework grants is not matched by machinery on the identity side. There is no mechanism for a Malian to view the data held on them in the national identity database or to see an access log, and data sharing between government bodies is ad hoc with no overarching data governance framework (2023); redress over the NINA and the biometric identity card runs through the general oversight of the ordinary courts, with no identification-specific mechanism (2025). Mali's digital freedom score fell 22.7 points over 2014-2023 to 38.5 out of 100, 40th of 54 African states (2023).

Where new watch duties have been distributed, they have gone to private parties rather than to a regulator: the justice ministry's July 2026 communiqué calls on parents, educators, building owners, landlords, managers of furnished flats, and bar and hotel keepers to watch for and denounce the conduct it targets, rather than on a

telecommunications or content regulator. Public bodies are training for the regime independently: the compulsory health insurance fund CANAM closed a staff session on personal-data management and protection, covering cyberattack, leakage and unauthorised access, on 28 August 2026.

Regional collaboration

Mali, Burkina Faso and Niger severed their ECOWAS ties in 2024, and the three share an Alliance of Sahel States agreement on identity credentials, under which Burkina Faso and Niger have launched regional biometric identity cards (March 2026). The bloc launched a common biometric passport to ease travel within the confederation on 29 January 2025, the same day Mali's exit from ECOWAS took effect.

What still binds Mali is monetary rather than political. Malian banks, payment institutions, microfinance institutions and e-money issuers are bound by BCEAO Instruction n° 003-03-2025 of 18 March 2025 on identification, identity verification and customer due diligence, applied uniformly across the eight UMOA states from Dakar, while payment systems run on Règlement n° 15/2002/CM/UEMOA and the central bank's instant payment platform for the eight WAEMU states, Mali among them, was launched on 30 September 2025.

On identity, Mali sits outside the ECOWAS architecture rather than having left it. The ECOWAS Commission's own account of the WURI regional identification programme names Benin, Burkina Faso, Côte d'Ivoire, Guinea, Niger and Togo as the implementing states, and not Mali, and the regional and cross-border interoperability strategy the WURI supervisory committee validated with the ECOWAS Commission and the World Bank in March 2026 is built for the programme's participating states.

Inside the confederation the instruments are new and thin. The customs directors-general signed a memorandum and framework instruction at Niamey on 23 July 2024 to interconnect their customs systems, starting with Togo, with no completed link on record. The telecoms regulators of Burkina Faso, Mali and Niger signed a convention creating a Council of Sahel Regulators, reported on 26 September 2026, with its statutes and first work programme still to be adopted; the three data protection authorities signed a roadmap for a coordination framework on 18 November 2025; and the communication ministry convened digital and media actors on 2 September 2026 on a common confederation framework for regulating social media, modelled on a Burkinabè reference text.

One regional instrument was written to reach Mali by either route. The 2010 ECOWAS Supplementary Act on personal data protection applies by its Article 3(3) to processing carried out in a UEMOA or an ECOWAS member state, and requires each member state to establish the legal framework and an independent data protection authority protected from instruction and from telecom-sector interests. Its entry into force is conditional under Article 48 on publication both in the Community's official journal and in each member state's own gazette.

Standards

Mali's standards agency went into 2026 with a budget about a quarter smaller: its fourteenth board session, in January 2026, was submitted a draft 2026 budget balanced at CFA 243,306,303 against CFA 318,369,036 in 2025, a fall of about a quarter. The standardisation and quality promotion agency was created by ordonnance n° 2012-016/P-RM of 19 March 2012 and is the international standards organisation's member body for Mali. No standard adopted or certification issued is published.

Mali has no dedicated data exchange or interoperability strategy and no published implementation roadmap (2025), and none of its core registers — commercial, civil registration, land and cadastre, tax, address and electoral — is connected to a national government data exchange platform (2023).

Electronic signatures have a narrow footing. They are recognised in Mali for payment-system purposes under Règlement n° 15/2002/CM/UEMOA, which also provides for netting and settlement finality. Behind that sits no regional certification policy: an ECOWAS and EU expert meeting on 26–27 March 2024 formulated guidelines and left a roadmap being defined, working from the Malabo Convention and the ECOWAS Supplementary Act on electronic transactions.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

Mali's cybercrime court sentenced Chahana Takiou, founder and publication director of the newspaper 22 septembre, to 12 months' imprisonment with 6 suspended on 3 August 2026, on a charge of atteinte au crédit de l'État à travers l'institution judiciaire. The remarks he was convicted over were made at the Forum panafricain des médias in Bamako in June 2026, where he argued that journalists prosecuted under Mali's cybercrime law should instead be tried under the press-offence law; a clip circulated, the cybercrime Pôle summoned him, and he was remanded in custody before trial. The sentence was exactly the one the prosecution had sought at the hearing of 27 July 2026.

The measured record moves the same way. Mali's media freedom score fell 9.1 points over 2014-2023 to 53.5 out of 100, 30th of 54, and its freedom of expression and belief score fell 24.4 points to 57.6, both inside a Rights sub-category down 12.4 points over the decade (2023).

Official argument about online speech is running through sovereignty. The justice ministry's July 2026 communiqué characterises the acts it targets as "importés d'ailleurs" and contrary to "nos valeurs sociétales", and the minister instructed prosecutors and judges at the end of July 2026 to act with rigour against those responsible for depraved content on social media, making enforcement a matter of prosecutorial instruction.

Civil society is working the same ground from the other side. Women Tech Mali launched Citoyens 2.0 in August 2026, a Malian application for countering disinformation, alongside a public campaign titled "Le vrai avant le viral", and a representative of the ministry responsible for communication and the digital economy endorsed it as bringing citizens closer to institutions, naming institutions, media, content creators and ordinary users as the four actors a disinformation response requires.

Finance

Financial sustainability

Mali's universal access fund cut its 2026 budget by a third after spending 8% of it in the first half: the AGEFAU board revised the budget from FCFA 41.15 billion to FCFA 27.89 billion in July 2026, the agency having collected FCFA 23.18 billion and spent FCFA 3.19 billion (2026). The government told the UN that the fund mobilised US$72 million in 2025 for network extension and telemedicine, and it has committed under four-year conventions with the education and employment ministries to connect every secondary, technical and vocational school by the end of 2027.

The 2025 credit-opening order carries FCFA 163.5 billion of external financing across 46 projects, none of them a digital line, and gives the ICT agency AGETIC FCFA 2.49 billion, the data-protection authority FCFA 2.06 billion and the finance ministry's tax and financial IT unit FCFA 1.56 billion (FY2025).

All of the FCFA 20.5 billion of digital lines in the 2025 order is the state's own money, against FCFA 19.6 billion in 2024 (FY2025).

The 2026 bill puts money on keeping the identity register in service: it proposes FCFA 636.4 million to extend the arrangements that sustain RAVEC, the biometric civil census, and FCFA 1 billion to build the civil-status data-processing centre (FY2026). No outturn against the digital appropriations of the state budget had been published as at September 2026.

MoUs and other agreements

No memorandum of understanding or comparable digital-sector agreement involving Mali had been concluded as at September 2026.

New investments

The largest digital money movement on Mali's record went to the state rather than into it: Sotelma, Maroc Telecom's Malian subsidiary trading as Moov Africa Malitel, paid XOF 160 billion in 2024 to renew its telecommunications licence, the single largest component of Maroc Telecom's licence and frequency costs across its Moov Africa subsidiaries that year.

The newest commitment runs the other way. The International Finance Corporation disclosed in 2025 a proposed senior unsecured loan to Orange Mali S.A. in CFA francs, recorded at about USD 79 million, for network modernisation, 4G expansion and mobile money infrastructure.

Sweden has financed Mali's statistics rather than its networks. Sida committed SEK 25,000,000 in December 2018 to co-fund the fifth general population and housing census, RGPH5, paid to the Institut National de la Statistique in Bamako that month under an activity that ran to 2025, and an amendment to the same census agreement added SEK 20,062,653, effectively all of it drawn down between 2021 and the activity's close in 2025 — some SEK 45 million of Swedish census money between them.

The government signed a concessional loan with the Export-Import Bank of China on 28 September 2018 to finance the Mali Digital 2020 project, with China International Telecommunications Construction Corporation as the commercial contractor. USAID funded a Digital Ecosystem Country Assessment from 2023, covering digital infrastructure, the regulatory environment and digital economy development.

Eight external digital commitments naming Mali are on the record, spanning 2018 to 2032 and worth roughly USD 531 million, one of them an innovation fund grant with no published amount, more than four-fifths of it in two telecommunications transactions dated 2018 and 2024; the West African regional operations that do not name the country sit outside that figure (September 2026).

As at October 2026 grants are four of the eight but under two per cent of the value, roughly USD 9 million, the rest carried by loans and by the licence transaction; connectivity takes almost all the value, while the most frequently financed subsector is national statistics — three commitments worth about USD 5 million, all of them Swedish support to the same census, making Sida the most frequent financier on the record.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

Internet use stood at 35.1% of the population in 2025, against mobile connections equivalent to 94% of it. Population coverage by at least a 4G network was 47% in 2021, and international bandwidth about 7 kbit/s per internet user in 2019 — the mark of a landlocked country dependent on cross-border terrestrial fibre and satellite.

Mali's ban on non-homologated Starlink and WiFi Zone equipment was reiterated in March 2026, during a wider SIM-card identification drive, with the transitional authorities holding that uncontrolled use of such equipment could expose the country to terrorist action. The retail market the restriction sits over is dominated by Orange Mali and Malitel, years of talk of a new operator licence having brought no competitive shift (August 2026), and mobile data is rated very expensive, a high-consumption basket costing more than 10% of gross national income per capita (2025).

The decade to 2023 was one of fast improvement from a low starting point. Mali's internet and computers score rose 19.8 points to 31.8 out of 100, its third most improved indicator and 29th of 54 African states, and its mobile communications score rose 19.9 points to 60.5, 37th of 54. The Infrastructure sub-category scored 36.4 out of 100, 30th of 54 and gained 8.4 points over the decade. Delivery infrastructure moved the other way: the postal and shipping network score fell 16.3 points to 15.6, 40th of 54 and among Mali's ten worst measures, while Malians' own assessment of infrastructure provision rose 13.6 points to 46.7, 16th of 54 and far above what the counted measures record.

Traffic exchange runs through a single internet exchange point, MLIX, established in Bamako in February 2018 and managed by the regulator AMRTP, with five participating networks. The Chinese-financed Mali Digital 2020 project was designed around intercity fibre connecting Kidal, Gao and Timbuktu to Mopti and running to the Guinean, Algerian and Burkinabè borders, with an urban network interconnecting government institutions. The Malian and Senegalese state fibre operators inaugurated the interconnection of their national backbones at the Kidira-Diboli border crossing on 5 October 2026.

Data Storage

Mali inaugurated a sovereign Tier III data centre in Bamako in early 2026, part of a gradual repatriation of data hosted outside the country. There is no hyperscale alternative close by: Malian users of the large cloud providers are served remotely from distant regions (2025).

Repatriation is a policy choice rather than a legal duty, since Mali's 2013 personal data protection law sets no general requirement to store data inside the country. What the state itself holds is thinner than the new building suggests: data sources and data infrastructure are the weakest of the World Bank's statistical pillars for Mali, well below its scores for data use and data services (2023).

Energy

Electricity has been rationed since late 2023, with households in Bamako down to four to six hours of power a day as of November 2025. The utility EDM's director-general said in March 2024 that the fuel and financial crisis had pushed thermal generation to about 70% of output, from 17% two decades earlier, and residential tariffs are among the highest in West Africa (2025).

Access reached 54.5% of the population in 2023, but the national figure conceals the split that matters for any service delivered outside the main centres: 91.5% of urban residents had electricity in 2023 against 22.7% of rural residents, a gap of 68.8 percentage points. Mali's access to energy score rose 10.2 points over 2014-2023 to 26.3 out of 100, 36th of 54 African states.

Off-grid provision is active rather than planned, run through AMADER's rural mini-grid programme (2024). Where the state has tried to digitise, power is one of the limits named: a July 2025 workshop on civil registration named poor connectivity, weak electricity access and insecurity as the barriers in rural areas.

Technical Capacity

Mali moved its national identity database in February 2024 to Mali Kura Biométrie, a sovereign platform built and maintained by Malian engineers, after a 2023 dispute in which the French vendor IDEMIA was accused of withholding access to the RAVEC/NINA database. Production of the biometric identity card is likewise handled by a Malian company, with a German supplier providing equipment and training under a technology-transfer arrangement, and the digitisation of bank-channel pension payments was built with technical support from PAFEEM, the entrepreneurship and employment financing project.

The equipment behind the institutions is improving faster than the institutions. Internet access across the structures of the national statistical system, coordinated by INSTAT under Law No. 2016-005, rose to 63% in 2024 from 49% in 2023, while intranet connectivity and working websites remain limited across many of them. The capacity of the statistical system scored 32.5 out of 100 in 2023, 46th of 54 African states and essentially unchanged over the decade — no improvement in the state's ability to count what it governs.

Public administration as a whole scored 46.6 out of 100 in 2023, 35th of 54, and fell 7.4 points over 2014-2023. Effective administration moved the other way, up 5.6 points to 48.2, 32nd of 54: the public service is judged more capable of delivering while the systems it delivers through score worse.

Cybersecurity

Mali's Council of Ministers approved a national cybersecurity strategy for 2026-2030 in December 2025. It starts from a weak position: the country scored 29.47 out of 100 on the ITU Global Cybersecurity Index 2024, in the fourth of five tiers, relatively strong on legal measures and weak on organisational and capacity-development ones. The Council of Ministers approved the creation of a national information systems security agency on 10 June 2026.

The enforcement apparatus is further ahead than the defensive one, and it is pointed at speech. The Pôle national de lutte contre la cybercriminalité, the specialised cybercrime prosecution and trial body, whose criminal chamber began hearing cases on 21 May 2026, tried a journalist on a charge of atteinte au crédit de l'État à travers l'institution judiciaire, and in August 2026 it convicted him, the publication director of the newspaper 22 septembre. Its reach has widened by instruction rather than by statute: the justice minister directed in July 2026 that networks trafficking in depraved content on social media be pursued under penal and cybercrime provisions already on the statute book, creating no new offence.

The Chinese-financed Mali Digital 2020 project was designed to include a state surveillance camera network and an internal secure communications network for the government, to be financed under the same concessional loan as the fibre backbone.

DPI

Data Exchange

Mali has no national data exchange platform, and the systems launched or expanded in September 2025 — Sigui-Dolo for transport licensing, OpenClinic for health, SIGIP for territorial administration and TrésorPay for payments — run as isolated sector platforms with no interoperability hub between them. None of the core registers — commercial, civil registration, land and cadastre, tax, address and electoral — connects to such a platform, and the technical foundations for cross-agency interoperability are absent (2023).

What linkage exists is narrow. Birth declarations recorded through the City-Web application at civil status centres feed the MorphoCivis interface that calculates and issues the NINA identification number (2024), and the one-stop investment shop API-Mali issues the commercial registration number and the tax identification number together

when a business is formed (2025). Elsewhere the join is made by hand: an applicant for a tax identification number submits a photocopy of the NINA card, with no interface or shared key behind it (2018). The Registre Social Unifié, set up by decree in May 2022 as an open system able to exchange with other national databases, takes the NINA number as one acceptable identifier among several rather than as its key.

The identity system is not yet joined to the new platforms: the health ministry's OpenClinic platform was presented in September 2025 with its link to the national identification number still a plan. Civil registration stands in the same place, largely paper-based with the connection to the NINA number planned rather than implemented (2025). Nothing above the sector level is set to change it: the replacement national digital economy strategy is still under development, leaving no interoperability roadmap, and sharing between government bodies runs case by case with no overarching data governance framework (2023).

Digital Identity and CRVS

Mali's identity system enables no digital authentication at all: it supports neither digital know-your-customer nor authentication through a government portal, and identity is verified by physical inspection of the document (2025). Behind it sits a biometric register of national scale — 5,733,428 biometric national identity cards produced against 8,463,084 people listed as eligible in the RAVEC database, roughly two-thirds, by August 2023.

The credential rests on Decree No. 2022-0639/PT-RM of 3 November 2022, which made the Carte Nationale d'Identité Biométrique Sécurisée the certified proof of identity in place of the NINA card, the ordinary identity card and the consular card. Enrolment captures fingerprints and a facial photograph, with no iris, a practice unchanged from the 2009-2011 RAVEC census to the 2025 biometric passport. Malians nonetheless rate the ease of obtaining an identity document at 69.9 out of 100, 8th of 54 African states and up 5.7 points over 2014-2023, against a collapsing civil registration score.

Ownership has been pulled home in one direction and pushed abroad in another. Mali migrated the register in February 2024 to Mali Kura Biométrie, a sovereign platform built and maintained by Malian engineers, after a 2023 dispute in which IDEMIA was accused of withholding access to the RAVEC/NINA database, and card production is carried out by the Malian company M-SI, with Germany's Dermalog supplying equipment and training (2024). Passport production went the other way, moving from IDEMIA to China's Emptech in October 2025, presented as a sovereignty measure.

Regionally Mali has changed camp. It launched a common Alliance of Sahel States biometric passport with Burkina Faso and Niger on 29 January 2025, the day its exit from ECOWAS took effect, and stands outside the ECOWAS foundational identity model, the WURI programme being implemented by six other West African states with the Commission.

Coverage of non-citizens is partial: refugees enrol through the National Refugee Commission and displaced people and returnees through the National Social Development Directorate, with no general provision for permanent residents or temporary workers (2023). The finance ministry has no documented role in the system, which sits with territorial administration and security, and whole-of-government coordination on digital identity is weak (2023).

Digital Payments and Fintech

59.8% of Malian adults made or received a digital payment in the 2024 Global Findex round, against 38% in 2021 — while the network that serves them shrank, mobile-money distributor numbers falling 46.34% during 2024, which the central bank puts down to distributors withdrawing as commissions were cut and the closure of inactive points.

Mali holds 10.7% of UEMOA e-money transaction volume and 11.7% of value, the value share down from 12.1% in 2023, 7.29% of the accounts opened in the Union, served by nine issuing establishments (December 2024), and is the Union's third largest country for cross-border digital flows, with 17 million intra-UEMOA operations worth 1,054 billion FCFA in 2024. Formal banking is another matter, access to banking services scoring 19.2 out of 100 in 2023 after a ten-point gain over the decade.

Instant payments arrived through the region: six participants based in Mali were authorised at the launch of the BCEAO's PI-SPI platform on 30 September 2025, and nineteen on the list the central bank published as at 30 September 2026, with the deadline to open the service set at 30 September 2026 for banks and e-money and payment institutions and 30 June 2027 for supervised microfinance institutions (June 2026); Orange Money's terms of use of August 2026 let its customers pay instantly from their wallets through the platform to any institution the central bank authorises. Clearing and settlement are not Mali's to run: the BCEAO operates SICA-UEMOA and STAR-UEMOA for all eight member states, and customer due diligence is set from Dakar by BCEAO Instruction n° 003-03-2025 of 18 March 2025, binding banks, payment institutions, microfinance institutions and e-money issuers alike.

Government pushes money in faster than out. An interministerial instruction of July 2024 mandates digital payment for a first list of public services, including taxes, fines, identity documents and passports, and digital payment raised nearly FCFA 200 million for local authorities between July 2024 and May 2026. Disbursement is still at pilot scale: the Jigisémèjiri mobile-money pilot in Mopti covered around 3,000 households and was framed as informing future scale-up in December 2023, mobile payment of pensions, introduced in 2019, reaches pensions below FCFA 50,000 (July 2026), and digital financial services lack established mechanisms for handling consumer complaints (November 2023).

Registries

Mali's civil registration score fell 37.5 points over 2014-2023 to 25.0 out of 100, 50th of 54 African states and the sixth most deteriorated of the 96 indicators measured for the country (2023).

The register it measures is only partly digitised. There are 747 primary civil status centres, 292 secondary centres and some 8,000 declaration points (2024). A UNICEF-supported platform to consolidate birth, death and marriage registration nationally has been piloted in ten zones since 2022 and not extended countrywide (2024), and a July 2025 workshop with members of the Conseil national de transition accepted that digitalisation remains insufficient, connectivity, electricity and insecurity binding in rural areas. Birth registration completeness stood at 87% (2018). The answer so far has been institutional: the Council of Ministers created an Agence nationale de sécurisation des actes d'état civil on 5 February 2025, which the national civil status directorate counts among the reforms behind its progress on birth registration.

Other registers are uneven. The commercial register has been computerised since September 2017 under an OHADA-backed programme. The NINACAD cadastral identifier, set by decree of 22 February 2019, is the single national identifier for every parcel and the only one the domains, cadastre and tax services recognise, while NINACAD-Adresse, a digital addressing application still at its design stage in January 2026, covers roughly 1.5 million locations concentrated in Bamako district and the towns of Kati, Ségou, Koulikoro, Markala and Sikasso, leaving the rural majority and most business premises without a standardised address. The electoral roll is a permanent biometric register drawn from the RAVEC population and civil registry databases, with biometric NINA cards used as voter identification, and held 8,463,085 registered voters at the June 2023 constitutional referendum.

Social protection has its own register, established by decree in May 2022 to cover beneficiaries of contributory and non-contributory schemes alike and still maturing, the most recent year of the World Bank-supported Sahel Adaptive Social Protection Programme spent strengthening its policy, systems and diagnostics (2025). Credit information is regional and private, Mali being covered by BIC-UEMOA, the credit bureau spanning all eight UEMOA states (August 2026).

The agency's board was named on 21 July 2026, including the digital-economy ministry and the civil-status director.

Sectoral management information systems

Police records in Mali are set by statute: the Code de Procédure Pénale in force since December 2024 requires judicial police officers to draft procès-verbaux on the spot, sign each sheet and send the original to the prosecutor, and lets the custody register be kept in electronic form. Mali also takes part in the INTERPOL-led West African Police Information System, which converts existing paper police records into a centralised national digital database (2024) — digitisation after the fact rather than at the point of capture.

Health follows the same shape. Community health workers collect, compile and report their data on a paper-based system, the health system having adopted DHIS2 for aggregation at facility level in 2015 (2021). OpenClinic, launched and expanded in September 2025, manages clinical, financial, pharmaceutical, laboratory and statistical records across a subset of facilities, and DISC-Mali has put tablet-based capture in the hands of community health workers for household visits since March 2023. One facility shows what a joined-up circuit looks like: the Hôpital dermatologie de Bamako runs registration, laboratory, consultation and pharmacy on a single unique patient identifier, with consultations and medicines paid electronically (July 2026).

In education, the management information system has no formal data-sharing protocol with the national statistics institute INSTAT and no link between learner records and any national data exchange (2017); the education ministry validated the specification and mock-up of a portal to manage teachers' postings and attendance in July 2026, with no build contract or launch date stated. Trade and customs run on their own platforms: the customs migration to ASYCUDA World had moved further offices into production by December 2018, with links to the single window, the treasury and the ports still pending, and the SYGOCE foreign-trade system, presented by the Prime Minister in May 2025, fully automates import requests including bank domiciliation. In agriculture, the AgData Hub hosted by Mali-Météo and the electronically registered farmer database used for input subsidy e-vouchers remain standalone donor- and research-led systems with no interoperability with tax, land or civil registration (2025).

Other GovTech and e-Gov

Mali's justice ministry extended its judicial records system in February 2026 with nationwide online platforms for criminal record extracts and nationality certificates whose documents carry the same legal validity as those issued in person, having launched the underlying case file system with the national ICT agency AGETIC in January 2025.

Other services have followed in quick succession. Sigui-Dolo, launched in September 2025, issues biometric driving licences and vehicle registration cards and is connected to the TrésorPay government payments platform for fee collection and to the SYDONIA customs system. The tax authority's e-Impôt platform, live since December 2021, carries tele-declaration and telepayment for large and mid-sized taxpayers at computerised tax centres, with online registration and digitised tax clearance certificates added from 2023. BAARA-ANPE, launched in June 2025, registers jobseekers, centralises their personal and professional data and matches them with employers nationally. Procurement went first: the SIGMAP procurement system was operational in five regions and the Bamako district by October 2021, with online bid submission still in preparation. The Prime Minister presented a microfinance refinancing platform, N'GNA SÔRÔ, credited with more than 642,000 beneficiaries through 17 financial institutions, and a tanker-truck gauging certificate system in May 2025. And a platform opened in February 2025 lets the

diaspora request administrative, identity and travel documents through diplomatic and consular missions. None of them can check a user against the identity register, which offers no authentication through a government portal (2025).

The measured position is well below that activity. Mali scored 0.3005 on the UN E-Government Development Index in 2024, 173rd of 193 member states, and its public administration sub-category — civil registration, statistical capacity, administrative effectiveness, revenue mobilisation and budget management — scored 46.6 out of 100 in 2023, 35th of 54 and down 7.4 points over a decade, with effective administration up 5.6 points to 48.2. The stated agenda is wider than what is running: the territorial administration ministry named digitalisation of public services, modernisation of civil registration, dissemination of the new administrative map and improvement of basic social services among its priorities in August 2026 and asked UNDP for reinforced support to deliver them, while the hosting is now domestic, with a sovereign Tier III data centre inaugurated in Bamako in early 2026.

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

Local authorities were ordered on 30 July 2026, at a meeting with the communes of Bamako District and Kati, to report within thirty days on how digital payment is functioning in each état civil centre — the difficulties met, the corrective measures taken, the equipment needed and what would improve it. Local authorities must also designate focal points to supervise digital payment at those centres and pass technical and financial information upward. The territorial administration ministry frames generalised digital payment as the instrument for ending fraudulent practice in local revenue collection, and the order came alongside publication of what the whole local-government tier had raised through the channel since July 2024.

Beneath that, digitalisation of the civil register is still partial. A UNICEF-supported platform for consolidating birth, death and marriage records nationally has been piloted since 2022 without a countrywide rollout (2024), and the network of civil status centres and declaration points administered by the DNEC is still being digitised (2024). In December 2025 the data protection authority opened a regional antenna in Ségou. The ministry of territorial administration named digitalisation of public services, modernisation of civil registration and dissemination of the new administrative map among its priorities in August 2026, and asked UNDP for reinforced support to deliver them.

The local-authorities directorate trained seven staff on the software and its central server in September 2023. It was reported tested in 680 communes in July 2024. The directorate's 2025 action plan adds a financial-control module.

A FCFA 9.407bn contract for a secure state network reaching local authorities was reported in June 2022, for 12 months. The Prime Minister launched it on 18 December 2023. In April 2025 the universal access agency was seeking to revive the September 2022 convention.

Rural digital data capture

Mali's digital services are concentrated in Bamako and the major cities, with rural areas held back by very limited connectivity and by instability and violence that hinder investment in networks (2024). At the rural service point itself the record is still made on paper: community health workers report on a paper-based system, with DHIS2 used for aggregation at facility level (2021). Digitisation begins one tier above the place where the fact is observed.

The breaks in that pattern run through donor-built systems rather than the administration. Community health workers have carried tablet-based capture for household visits since March 2023. Mali's agricultural data holdings — a hub hosted by Mali-Météo integrating climate, soil and crop data, and an electronically registered farmer database used for input subsidy e-vouchers — are standalone systems that do not connect to tax, land or civil registration (2025).

None of this has stopped rural Mali scoring well on the things the register does not hold. Rural Economy is the country's strongest Ibrahim Index sub-category by a wide margin, at 69.4 out of 100 and 13th of 54 African states, up 11.1 points over 2014-2023 — the largest ten-year gain of any of its sixteen sub-categories (2023). Rural market access reached 75.6 and 10th place (2023), and rural representation and participation 80.5 and 8th place, up 17.4 points over the same decade and Mali's fourth most improved indicator (2023). What has not moved with them is the physical basis for capture: rural electricity access remains far below the urban rate (2023), and 4G population coverage is well short of universal (2021).

Technology

AI

Mali's tax authority set out artificial intelligence as an ambition rather than a working tool in November 2025, describing a planned data warehouse with business intelligence and artificial intelligence tools to detect inconsistencies and combat fraud, with no date attached to it. The state's own money has gone first into research capacity: the artificial intelligence and robotics centre was inaugurated at Kati Sirakoro Niaré on 21 September 2026, a 50-hectare, six-block site with a fabrication and assembly workshop for intelligent systems, financed entirely from the national budget at FCFA 3.3 billion. The working models so far are a private lab's: RobotsMali released a 612-hour transcribed Bambara speech dataset with fine-tuned recognition models in November 2025, after two open-source Bambara speech models trained on about 35 hours of audio in February 2025.

ICT Industry

Mali's economic diversification score fell 28.5 points over 2014-2023 to 18.3 out of 100, 53rd of 54 African states, placing it among both the country's ten worst-scoring and ten most deteriorated indicators (2023). The industrial base is narrowing rather than broadening, which is the setting any account of a technology sector here has to start from.

The rules moved the same way, less far. Business and competition regulations scored 51.5 out of 100, ranking 30th of 54, down 8.8 points across the same decade, inside a business and labour environment sub-category scoring 39.9 and ranked 38th (2023). Mali is mid-table on the regulatory frame and second from last on what the economy actually produces, so the constraint on a technology industry is not principally the rulebook.

What that sector consists of is not counted: no business or establishment census has been taken in twenty years and no such survey in ten (2023), so no official count of firms exists to size an ICT industry against. The organised activity that is visible sits in a hub and incubator layer (2026) rather than in enumerated firms.

Innovation ecosystem

The newest visible output of Mali's innovation base came from civil society, not from a firm or a state programme: Women Tech Mali launched Citoyens 2.0, an application for countering disinformation, in August 2026, alongside a public campaign titled "Le vrai avant le viral".

The organised part of it is a hub layer. Impact Hub Bamako, Jokkolabs Mali, Nyetaa Mali and Expert'labs Mali are among the Malian hubs on AfriLabs' membership list, with an Orange Digital Center and a university incubator alongside them (2026). The state's own instruments for start-ups are slow to arrive. The Council of Ministers adopted a start-up bill in October 2019, its adoption was billed as imminent in June 2024, and a start-up law was recommended again in August 2026; the ministry's Mali Digital Accélérateur, offering training, mentoring and funding, was reported launched in April 2025 with no cohort size or budget published. Against international measurement the country places 131st in WIPO's Global Innovation Index 2024, in the bottom quartile of the ranked economies.

Capacity

Literacy

Human Resources in Education is the single one of the Ibrahim Index's 96 indicators for which Mali returns no data at all, so it cannot be scored or ranked (2023).

Where Mali is scored, the direction is down. Education quality fell 7.5 points over 2014–2023 to 19.0 out of 100, 46th of 54 African states, and enrolment stands at 21.5, 47th and 2.0 points lower than a decade earlier — even as the education sub-category as a whole rose 2.8 points to 36.3, Mali's third worst sub-category score of any measured (2023).

Use of the internet by adults is roughly two in five: 42% used it at some frequency and 25% used it daily, while 58% had never used it at all (2022); the demographic and health survey of 2023-24 found 63% of men and just over four women in ten had ever used it.

Training for officials is project-financed. The universal access fund is paying FCFA 200 million to train 504 elected officials and staff of 126 communes in office software, the first 84 from 21 communes in September 2026, and a Global Fund contract to August 2026 continues the health ministry's e-learning platform.

Training and skills

Tertiary computer science is taught in the private sector as well as the public one: the Université du Sahel in Bamako runs a dedicated faculty of computer science in the capital. What feeds those programmes is the constraint — the quality of Malian schooling fell over the decade to 2023, to 46th of 54 African states.

Outside the universities the largest programme is for young people: a first cohort of 1,000 began four months of bursaried digital training in August 2026, under a three-year convention signed on 31 January 2026 to train 15,000.

Inside the state, training has come agency by agency rather than as a programme. The compulsory health insurance fund CANAM closed a session on personal-data management, cybersecurity and protection against leakage and unauthorised access on 28 August 2026, delivered by a private firm. Card and payment operations training under a BCEAO programme was completed at all the Malian sites concerned, alongside five other UEMOA members (2023).

The state's own record of who is looking for work was digitised in mid-2025, when the National Employment Agency launched a platform to register jobseekers and match them with employers nationally.

Research institutions

Mali ranked 131st in the Global Innovation Index in 2024, in the bottom quartile of the ranked economies.

Inclusion

Access to services

Mali's score for equal access to public services fell 4.2 points over 2014-2023, to 30.4 out of 100 and 39th of 54 African states (2023). Services reach people less evenly than they did a decade earlier.

The clearest gain is legal. Mali adopted a dedicated statelessness law in June 2025 creating a pathway to registration and nationality, and since 2017 nearly 2,400 people at risk of statelessness have been naturalised and more than 30,000 have received birth certificates and other civil documents. Enrolment routes also exist for refugees through the National Refugee Commission and for displaced people and returnees through the National Social Development Directorate, though no general provision extends registration to other non-nationals such as permanent residents or temporary workers (2023).

Price is the barrier that binds hardest on the services that do exist. A high-consumption mobile data basket costs 51.5% of gross national income per capita (2025). For a household at or near the average income, a data plan of that size is not a purchasing decision.

Digital delivery of state payments has not moved past pilot scale: mobile-money disbursement of social transfers in Mopti was still being framed as informing a future scale-up in December 2023, with cash, vouchers and mobile money in parallel use. Where digital financial services do reach people, recourse mechanisms for handling consumer complaints are not established (November 2023), and standardised digital addressing covers Bamako district and a handful of towns (2025), leaving the rural majority and most business premises without an address a service can be delivered to.

Digital divides

Women's access to public services in Mali scored 13.3 out of 100 in 2023, 47th of 54 African states, placing it among the country's ten worst-scoring governance indicators even after a rise of 4.3 points over the preceding decade. It is the sharpest of Mali's inclusion divides and the one least visible in the connectivity figures.

The use divide runs almost as deep. 58% of Malian adults reported never using the internet, with 42% using it at some frequency and 25% doing so daily (2022). The pattern behind that is a country whose mobile reach has improved fast while its internet use has not: Mali's mobile communications score rose 19.9 points over 2014-2023 to 60.5 out of 100, its second most improved indicator of 96, while its internet and computers score reached only 31.8 out of 100 on the same measure (2023) despite a comparable rate of improvement. Coverage has arrived; use has not followed it. The gap is also one of sex: 87% of men and 66% of women own a phone, and 63% of men against just over four women in ten have ever used the internet (2023-24).

Geography is the divide that has moved least. Digital services remain concentrated in Bamako and the major cities, with rural areas held back by very limited connectivity and by instability that deters network investment (2024). Beneath that sits the urban-rural split in electricity access, which settles whether a household can power a device at all before any question of coverage or price arises.

Data

National statistics

The system's planning cycle ran out in 2024 and its successor reached the Council of Ministers in October 2026. The statistical master plan covered 2020-2024 and the Council of Ministers took note on 9 October 2026 of a fourth plan and its action plan for 2026-2030, set on four axes running from the management of the statistical system to the

dissemination and use of its output, though the text itself is not held; the public statistics law of 24 February 2016 is the instrument behind it and behind the national statistics council. Mali's statistical system uses data far better than it collects it: on the World Bank's Statistical Performance Indicators it scores above 89 per cent on data use and between 50 and 69 per cent on data services and products, but only 20 to 49 per cent on both data sources and data infrastructure, the two pillars that measure the collection systems underneath (2023). The gap shows most plainly in the enterprise sector, which has had no business or establishment census in twenty years and no such survey in the last ten, leaving firms without a statistical frame even as household, labour force, health and agricultural surveys were fielded three or more times over the same decade (2023).

The fifth general population and housing census, which Malian law requires every ten years and which was planned for fieldwork in 2019, only concluded in 2022, delayed by the country's infrastructure and security conditions. Sweden, which co-funded it through INSTAT, then paid for a separate special review of the census at SEK 599,826, an activity opened and closed within 2024.

The state's ability to count what it governs has not moved in a decade: Mali's capacity of the statistical system score stood at 32.5 out of 100 in 2023, 46th of 54 African states and 0.2 points below where it was ten years earlier. Connectivity inside the system is improving, with internet access across the structures of the National Statistical System, coordinated by INSTAT under Law No. 2016-005, reaching 63 per cent in 2024 from 49 per cent in 2023, while intranet links and working websites remain scarce across many member bodies.

Where the numbers begin, capture is still on paper: rural clinics keep patient encounters on paper registers and send only aggregated monthly totals to the national DHIS2 platform (2025). A peer review of the education management information system found it had no formal data-sharing protocol with INSTAT (2017).

Open data

The state has grown less forthcoming about its own affairs over the past decade. Mali's disclosure of public records score stood at 21.4 out of 100 in 2023, 42nd of 54 African states and 5.1 points down over ten years. What a citizen can obtain by asking has moved the other way, accessibility of public records rising 3.9 points to 32.3 out of 100 over the same period, 24th of 54 — better than most of the continent at answering a request, near the bottom at volunteering anything unasked.

Published statistics are strongest where the money and the crops are: in the 2024 Open Data Inventory, government finance, price indexes and agriculture each score 7.5 out of 10, while health outcomes and money and banking reach 4.5 and trade 4. No openness score is recorded at all for energy, pollution or the digital and communications category (2024).

Nothing sits above these publications as a rule. Data sharing between government bodies is ad hoc, with no overarching data governance framework, and a Malian has no way to see what the national identity database holds on them or who has looked at it (2023).

Use of satellite data

Mali's earth observation and geospatial holdings sit almost entirely in agriculture and weather. The AgData Hub hosted by Mali-Météo brings climate, soil and crop data together, and a separate electronically registered farmer database drives input subsidy e-vouchers, both standalone donor- and research-led systems with no interoperability with tax, land or civil registration systems (2025). Mali-Météo commissioned receiving stations for Meteosat Third Generation data on 10 March 2026 under the African Union's PUMA 2025 programme and ClimSA initiative.

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

USAID commissioned a Digital Ecosystem Country Assessment of Mali in 2023, examining digital infrastructure, the regulatory environment and digital economy development in order to shape its own programming.

China activities

China supplies both the finance behind Mali's national backbone and the vendor that prints its passports: production of the biometric passport moved from France's IDEMIA to China's Emptech in October 2025, a switch the government presented as a digital sovereignty measure while leaving the credential in the hands of a foreign supplier.

The finance runs through the Mali Digital 2020 Project, a non-concessional loan of RMB 1,134,000,000 signed with the Export-Import Bank of China at Beijing on 28 September 2018 and ratified by Loi n°2018-066 with China International Telecommunications Construction Corporation as the commercial contractor. The scope agreed that year reached well beyond connectivity: intercity fibre linking Kidal, Gao and Timbuktu to Mopti and running out along the Algerian, Guinean and Burkinabè border routes, an urban fibre network interconnecting government institutions, an electronic identity card system, and a camera surveillance network with a secure internal communications channel for the government. One foreign lender therefore stood behind the state's long-distance network, its government intranet, an identity credential and a surveillance capability at the same time. The scope was cut back in January 2024, when the Council of Ministers approved a USD 117,387,180.77 amendment to the works contract that replaced the Mopti, Koro, Timbuktu, Gao, Ansongo and Labenzaga sites with western ones, redesigned the backbone route, reserved the data centre and deleted the electronic-identity component.

The project carried a 2020 completion date, and China's ambassador visited the works in February 2019.

The Eximbank loan is one of the two transactions that dominate Mali's digital finance by value (September 2026), at roughly USD 187 million against about USD 256 million for Maroc Telecom's renewal of the Sotelma licence, and well ahead of the IFC's roughly USD 79 million.

EU activities

The European Union had no digital-sector financing commitment or cooperation programme in Mali as at September 2026.

Gulf/UAE activities

No Gulf state or Gulf-based development financier had a digital-sector financing commitment in Mali as at September 2026.

India activities

India had no digital-sector financing commitment or cooperation programme in Mali as at September 2026.

Digital sovereignty

Mali is bringing state hosting home: the national Tier III data centre inaugurated in Bamako at the start of February 2026 is to host the state's strategic data, e-administration platforms and public digital services and, in the short term, shared infrastructure for Niger and Burkina Faso, and the communications minister says it was financed and is run locally, the three Sahel states having pledged to repatriate their data (February 2026). No instrument fixing where state data is held or under whose law it is processed was in force as at September 2026. The fourth Semaine du

Numérique in August 2026 recommended a data-management law, a law making the state company SMTD-SA the sole national operator of transport, transmission, storage and broadcast infrastructure, and a Sahel-confederation protocol harmonising AI governance.

The state raised its stake in the incumbent operator SOTELMA from 49% to 56% in June 2026, leaving Maroc Telecom a minority shareholder. Passport production resumed in October 2025 under a new Malian-law contractor, SECU-PASS Mali; whether the state holds the source code and operating skills for the e-passport system, or can exit that contract, was not on record as at September 2026. The terms on which the 2018 China Eximbank-financed Mali Digital 2020 contract, covering the government intranet and surveillance cameras, governs data jurisdiction, portability and exit had not been published as at September 2026. The software layer stays licensed from abroad: the ICT agency AGETIC's 2026 procurement plan renews government messaging and collaboration licences at FCFA 240 million, with Windows and Microsoft Office, Linux server, Fortigate and SolarWinds licences beside them (2026).

The state's AI runs on its own premises: the state intelligence service's Lakana 360 surveillance platform, engineered with a foreign commercial AI model, runs fully on premises on local models, so the model vendor's closure of the builder's account did not affect it (September 2026). Mali asked the UN's global dialogue on AI governance in July 2026 for binding rules guaranteeing developing countries the sovereign right to govern their national data.

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